SIX

‘Sometimes I wish I too had a palace,’ Hema sighed. We were standing outside the Mysore Palace, which was lit up by hundreds of lights. ‘A king-sized life, tens of people tending to my needs, big feasts, chauffeurs to drive me around, travel and adventure!’

The huge palace, the official residence of the royal family of Mysore, exhibited a perfect blend of the Hindu, Islamic and Gothic architectural styles and was circled by a colourful garden, filled with numerous flowers and plants. Trivia about the place was written on a tourist information board, which I was reading along with the other visitors.

‘Our military also offers a somewhat similar lifestyle,’ I said as I continued to read.

‘Absolutely!’ Hema agreed at once. ‘The uniform, the Gypsy with a driver, the dinner parties at the mess—it’s almost the same. But it comes at a cost.’

‘A cost we’re ready to pay, right?’ I said, and she smiled.

The next two days after the GD had been busy and tiring. We had appeared for the Group Obstacle Race (GOR), the Individual Obstacles (IO), the Progressive Group Tasks (PGT) and the Half Group Task (HGT) tests, which were conducted by a group testing officer (GTO). An officer of the Indian armed forces is required to face situations that test his/her fitness and qualities in many ways. The aim of the above-mentioned tests is to